

to look at next is what was this language, what does it entail, and why is Microsoft pushing for it.

Why Modern UI

Computer technology is hardly old, but it has its baggage.

Take a look at email which is, at this point, around four decades old. It was created at a time when transferring files over a few kB per second was an immense luxury. It was designed as a simple system with a sender, a recipient, and a text message.

Then as its use evolved and expanded there was a need for protecting against spam, or using hosted email service, or sending attachments. Since email was designed for text, attachments would initially have to be converted to plain text, increasing their size in the process, pasted in the mail, and then sent. The recipient could then paste that attached text content in a file, and decode it to get the original binary.

Today this process is transparent, and attachments show up as nice clean file icons in webmail, but the technology is still plagued with the limitations of the past.

In 2009 Google decided to take matters into its own hands and unveiled the future of communication, Google Wave. Google Wave was designed with one thing in mind, what would an email-like communication system look like, and work like if it was created today. Wave supported inline replies, instant messages, widgets, bots; it was an open system so like email, any company could run a wave service.

In the time since its release it has now replaced 90% of email and IM conversation. But only in an alternate universe that in this authors words would have been “totally awesome”.

The reality is, it was a huge flop. Maybe it needed more time, maybe it was half baked and tried to do too much. It doesn't matter, Google gave up.

You may be wondering what this has to do with Microsoft, Windows 8 and Modern UI. Here is what; When we look at how the GUI has evolved, we will find similar anachronisms, aspects of UI design that exist because they existed in the past, because they are familiar and for no other reason.

What would a user interface look like if it was created for the computers of today? Or perhaps more accurately if it did not have baggage from the past?

Microsoft thinks their design language is the answer. Microsoft is pushing it hard because that is the only way to bring changes to things that are widely accepted.